

In-Flight Movies

Meher Ahmad

The New York Times Magazine. (Nov. 26, 2017): Lifestyle: p20(L). From *Literature Resource Center*.

Copyright: COPYRIGHT 2017 The New York Times Company

<http://www.nytimes.com>

Full Text:

The flight attendant passing a tomato juice to my seatmate did a double-take when she saw my tear-streaked face. She touched my shoulder: "Ma'am, are you doing O.K.?" I wiped the gobs of snot from my nose, pulled my headphones off and gave her that awkward, forced smile you do when you're crying but want the other person to leave you alone. She obliged.

I was watching "Lion," the Garth Davis film about a young Indian boy adopted by nice, white Australians, but I would have reacted the same way if I were watching a David Attenborough nature documentary. I wasn't even two minutes into the film when the first tear rolled down my cheek dramatically and my lower lip started quivering.

Crying on planes is so common that it has prompted cheeky "weep warnings" on Virgin Atlantic flights and myriad articles trying to understand why we do it. The most accepted explanation is a simple confluence of altitude, loneliness and the heightened emotions that accompany the humiliating experience that is modern air travel.

I've been dealing with clinical anxiety, the most millennial of maladies, since I was a teenager. I experienced my first full-fledged anxiety attack in a Metro car in Paris, and after that I became a panicked traveler regardless of whether I was on the ground or in the air. Over time, my phobia shifted to become about crying itself -- which then made it inevitable that I would cry, in that prophetic way anxiety manifests itself. Once, on a short flight from Marseille to Paris, I caught the panic creeping up slowly enough that I flagged the flight attendant, hoping she could somehow reverse the oncoming hyperventilation with a chic Air France accouterment. "Just pretend she is a biiiig bus," she crooned in Franglais, assuming my anxiety derived from a fear of flying rather than from my actual fear: people seeing me cry in public.

Though I come on my mother's side from a long line of Shiites, who encourage public grieving through institutionalized mourning called matam, there's little I find more mortifying than crying in front of strangers. Matam is the act of grieving Imam Hussain, the Prophet Muhammad's grandson, who was martyred along with his followers in a bloody battle in the year 680. Our tears and self-flagellations are meant to be in remembrance of Hussain's agony, but it's actually a chance for us to grieve about our own quotidian sufferings. It's difficult not to cry when you attend a majlis, or the congregation for matam.

My mother, my aunts, my grandmother and her sisters have between them survived multiple wars, a violent escape from their small town in what is now India during the Partition and an economic exodus that took their children and grandchildren to far-flung places like Minneapolis and Indianapolis, the opposite end of the world from Pakistan. Still, they don't really cry outside a majlis. The ritual allows them to break

down without any of the judgment that is otherwise associated with being a wailing woman in public. The few times I've been with them, I sat on the floor in the ladies' section of the mosque and watched as they dissolved into sobbing, shaking piles of dark fabric. My face stayed dry.

I pride myself in rarely crying or displaying any emotion at all, so having panic attacks meant my anxieties came out all at once. They weren't expected, and their erratic appearances are precisely what made them debilitating. At my worst, I convinced myself that my fear of weeping on planes would stop me from flying altogether, but then I began relishing the idea of flipping through the in-flight movie catalog on a clumsy touch-screen, calmly selecting a straight-to-DVD film that would reduce me to tears.

On a plane, the principles of film selection are suspended as long as we're at cruising altitude: It's fine -- welcome, even -- to watch a bad movie. I've found myself dabbing my eyes through "Murder, She Baked," a series of films created by Hallmark Movies & Mysteries, and have somehow choked up at "Taken 2" and "Taken 3" -- anything in which the music swells. I had little interest in watching "Lion" in theaters or at home, but I knew it would give me the opportunity to freely weep at someone else's anxieties instead of my own. Above all, it gave me an excuse to cry when there seemed to be a reason to, a semblance of control.

By the time the plane begins its descent, I'm blotchy-eyed but emotionally sound; I'm still riding the high of postcrying calmness while standing in the airport taxi line. The rhythm to the ritual is comforting enough that I don't even need to discreetly nibble off-brand Xanax in my seat; it has replaced my new-age meditation completely. The idea of letting my weepy alter-ego make a controlled appearance is so appealing that I sometimes wonder whether I travel just to give my tear ducts a test run.

A kind woman sitting cater-corner to my seat watched me dissolve into the hiccuppy kind of crying by the last scene of "Lion," handing me her allotted single in-flight napkin after seeing that mine was soaked. Airlines are stingy with everything, but it seems inhumane that they aren't willing to hand out more napkins during a service, given that everyone acknowledges that in-flight movies make them cry. At Shiite mosques, they like to put boxes of pink, perfumed Rose Petal brand tissues around the room before people arrive for prayer. At least they're prepared.

Sign up for our newsletter to get the best of The New York Times Magazine delivered to your inbox every week.

CAPTION(S):

DRAWING There's more than one ritual that provides cover for public weeping.
(DRAWING BY JAVIER JA[ETH]N)

Source Citation (MLA 8th Edition)

Ahmad, Meher. "In-Flight Movies." *The New York Times Magazine*, 26 Nov. 2017, p. 20(L). *Literature Resource Center*, <https://link.gale.com/apps/doc/A515652491/LitRC?u=mainz&sid=LitRC&xid=b76270ed>. Accessed 15 Aug. 2019.

Gale Document Number: GALE|A515652491